

tion in the last 24 hours. But better tools do not help if users grant everything blindly. Privacy is not a feature you own by default. It is a habit you practise.

## Why permissions matter more in India

For Indian users, phone privacy is not abstract. The Android phone often carries UPI apps, banking apps, Aadhaar PDFs, PAN scans, passport photos, property documents, school forms, office emails, family WhatsApp media, location trails, delivery addresses, call histories and years of SMS alerts. It is a document locker, wallet, communication hub and identity layer. That makes permissions far more serious than a boring technical pop-up.

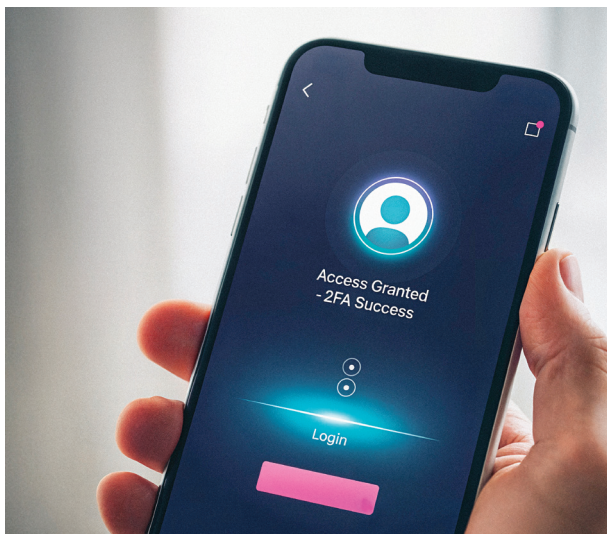
This is also why shady apps are dangerous. A fake loan app asking for contacts is not merely annoying. It can use social pressure as a weapon. A random APK asking for SMS access can become an OTP risk. A photo-editing app asking for full file access may get more than selfies. A flashlight app asking for location, contacts and microphone is waving a red flag large enough to need its own flagpole.

The first principle is simple: an app should get only what it needs to perform the job you asked it to do.

## Understand the permission language

Android's permission choices are more nuanced than yes or no. For location, you may see Allow all the time, Allow only while using the app, Ask every time, and Don't allow. Google's location permissions help page explains that users can see apps under those categories and change access app by app.

For most apps, Allow only while using is enough. Maps needs location while navigating. A cab app needs it while booking or during a ride. A weather app may need approximate location, not exact GPS. A social media app probably does not need constant background location. Background access should be rare and justified.



For camera and microphone, be stricter. A video meeting app needs both during calls. A camera app needs the camera. A scanner app needs the camera. But if a shopping app, wallpaper app or casual game wants microphone access, ask why. If there is no obvious reason, deny it.

For contacts, be even more cautious. Contacts are not only your data. They are other people's information stored on your phone. Granting contact access to a random app is like handing over someone else's visiting card collection without asking.

## Step-by-step: run your first permission audit

- Open Settings.
- Search for Permission manager.
- Tap Location.
- Review apps under Allowed all the time. Move almost everything to Allow only while using or Ask every time, unless background access is genuinely necessary.
- Go back and open Camera.
- Remove camera access from apps that do not clearly need it.
- Open Microphone.
- Remove microphone access from apps that are not used for calls, recordings, voice notes, camera, meetings or voice search.
- Open Contacts, SMS, Call logs, Files, or Photos and videos, depending on what your phone shows.
- Revoke access wherever the reason is unclear.

Do not try to perfect everything in one heroic session. Start with the sensitive permissions first: location, camera, microphone, contacts, SMS and files. That alone puts you ahead of most users.

## Privacy Dashboard: your rear-view mirror

The Permission Manager shows who can access what. Privacy Dashboard shows who recently did. That distinction is important. An app may have permission and never use it. Another app may access location, camera or microphone repeatedly. Privacy Dashboard helps you see behaviour, not just eligibility.

Google's Android help says users can open Security and Privacy or Privacy, tap Privacy dashboard, select the permission they are concerned about, and then update an app's permission from there. This is one of the easiest ways to catch suspicious activity.

## Step-by-step: check recent sensitive access

- Open Settings.
- Search for Privacy Dashboard.
- Tap Location and see which apps accessed it recently.
- Tap Camera.
- Tap Microphone.
- If an app appears at a strange time, tap it.